

STRATEGY

How to Run a Brand Audit

A practical framework for assessing where your brand currently stands — before deciding what needs to change.

How to Run a Brand Audit

A brand audit is the diagnostic work that should precede any major brand investment — a structured assessment of how your brand currently looks, sounds, and performs compared to what it could be. Done well, an audit eliminates guesswork from the brief.

■ The three dimensions of a brand audit

A complete brand audit assesses the brand across three dimensions: visual (how it looks), verbal (how it sounds), and perceptual (how it's actually perceived by the audiences that matter). Many audits cover the first two but skip the third — which is the most important one.

■ Visual audit

Collect every brand asset currently in use and evaluate them for consistency, quality, and distinctiveness.

- ☐ Gather every version of the logo in use across all teams and geographies
- ☐ Screenshot every digital brand touchpoint: website, app, social profiles, email templates
- ☐ Collect physical brand materials: business cards, packaging, signage, printed collateral
- ☐ Evaluate consistency: do all these assets feel like they belong to the same brand?
- ☐ Evaluate quality: is the visual standard consistent, or do some touchpoints look significantly better than others?
- ☐ Evaluate distinctiveness: could this brand be confused with a competitor?

■ Verbal audit

Collect every instance of brand copy currently in use and evaluate for consistency, voice, and clarity.

- ☐ Collect headline copy from all primary marketing channels
- ☐ Gather product descriptions, landing pages, and onboarding communications
- ☐ Review social media voice across all handles
- ☐ Read the sales team's email templates and pitch scripts
- ☐ Evaluate: does this all sound like one brand, or like multiple people with different ideas about what we are?
- ☐ Identify the phrases and claims that are repeated most often — are they intentional, or defaults?

■ Competitive visual mapping

Place your brand in its competitive landscape and assess whether you're occupying distinctive territory or blending in.

- ☐ Create a visual map of all primary competitors' brand identities
 - ☐ Identify the visual conventions that dominate the category (colours, type choices, photography styles)
 - ☐ Identify the territory that's underoccupied — where could a brand stand out?
 - ☐ Evaluate whether your brand's visual position is intentional or accidental
-

| Audience perception audit

This is the hardest part of the audit to conduct honestly — it requires gathering evidence of how the brand is actually perceived, not how you'd like it to be.

- ☐ Review customer testimonials and review platform mentions for brand-related language
 - ☐ Survey a sample of customers: what three words would you use to describe this company?
 - ☐ Survey non-customers in your target audience: what do you associate with this company?
 - ☐ Interview 5–10 customers about their first impression of the brand
 - ☐ Review what your sales team hears when prospects talk about your brand
-

| Audit output: the gap analysis

The output of a brand audit is not a list of things that are wrong — it's a gap analysis that shows the distance between how the brand is currently perceived and how it needs to be perceived to achieve its strategic goals. This gap is the brief for the subsequent brand work.
